

The Common Sense Department Appears to Be Closed

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Essay

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When “clean your room” somehow requires a project manager, a glossary, and a federal inquiry into the location of the laundry basket.

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There is a special kind of silence that happens when you ask a kid to clean their room.

Not silence like peaceful silence. Not the kind where birds chirp and the house settles and you think, briefly and foolishly, maybe this is the day everyone becomes normal. I mean the silence of a teenager standing in the doorway of a bedroom that looks like a sporting goods store, a laundromat, and a minor weather event all collided, and then looking back at you like you just handed them a scroll written in ancient Greek.

“Clean your room.”

“What do you mean?”

What do I mean?

I mean clean your room. I mean reverse whatever archaeological process has been happening in there since last Tuesday. I mean locate the floor. I mean gather the socks, the hoodies, the dishes that have apparently decided to start their own civilization, the water bottles, the wrappers, the chargers, and whatever that thing is under the bed that I am not touching unless the county gets involved.

I mean clean your room.

But that is not enough anymore. Somehow the sentence “clean your room” has become too vague, too open-ended, too full of dangerous interpretive possibilities. It apparently requires a project manager, three bullet points, a risk assessment, and maybe a follow-up meeting with snacks.

To be fair, I know this sounds like every parent in every generation complaining that the young people are broken. I get it. Somewhere in 1958, some father probably stood in a garage, holding a rake, wondering why his son could not figure out that “clean up the yard” included the leaves, the tools, and the bicycle lying sideways in the driveway like a crime scene. This is not new in the broadest sense. Kids have always needed direction. Kids have always been kids.

But something does feel different right now.

It is not that my kids are dumb. They are not. It is not that they are bad kids. They are not. It is not even that they are lazy all the time, though let’s not get ridiculous and pretend laziness has left the building. These are good kids. Funny kids. Capable kids. Kids who can learn complicated video game systems, navigate apps I have never heard of, find obscure YouTube channels dedicated to ranking fictional swords, and operate a phone with the speed and confidence of a stock trader during a mild panic.

But ask them to complete a basic real-world task without step-by-step instructions and suddenly we are pioneering westward in a covered wagon.

That is the part that makes my left eye twitch.

I grew up in the 1980s and 1990s, which means my childhood was basically a loosely supervised experiment in minor danger and practical learning. We figured things out because, most of the time, nobody was standing there to translate life into manageable sub-tasks. You wanted cereal? You got a bowl, poured the cereal, checked the milk with the sniff test, made a judgment call, and lived with the consequences. You wanted to ride your

bike somewhere? You told your mom, she said, “Be back before dark,” and then you entered a world of freedom, bad decisions, and questionable helmet use.

Nobody gave us a checklist for existing.

When I looked for my first job, I did not sit at the kitchen table waiting for my parents to assemble a career development packet. I chose where I wanted to apply. I asked for a ride so I could pick up applications. I walked into each place, filled out the application on the spot, and asked if I could speak to someone about an interview. Was I nervous? Of course I was. I was a teenager, which means I was made almost entirely of awkwardness, cheap deodorant, and misplaced confidence. But I did it.

Nobody had to explain that getting a job required action.

With my older boys, the process felt different. Looking for a job somehow became a family administrative burden. Where should I apply? Can you find the applications? Do I have to fill this out? What should I put here? Should I call them? What do I say? Can you just help me do it?

Help is one thing. I am not opposed to helping my kids. I want to help them. That is part of the job. But there is a difference between helping someone carry a load and carrying the load while they walk next to you holding a smoothie and asking when you will be done.

At some point, you want to say, “Son, I love you, but I cannot want your life more than you do.”

And that is where the humor starts to leak into something more serious.

Because the question is not just, “Why can’t my kids think for themselves?” The real question is, “Have we accidentally trained them not to?”

I don’t know. I really don’t. I am not standing here as the great champion of perfect parenting. In true Rob fashion, I am fully capable of identifying a cultural problem five minutes after realizing I may have contributed to it in my own kitchen.

We wanted to protect our kids. That is not a bad instinct. We wanted them safe, supported, and better guided than we were. A lot of that is good. A hell of a lot of it is good.

But maybe somewhere along the way, guidance became management.

Maybe we replaced “figure it out” with “here are the seven steps.” Maybe every time they bumped into normal confusion, we treated it like an emergency instead of a teacher.

There is a kind of learning that only happens in the uncomfortable little gap between not knowing what to do and deciding what to try next. That gap is where judgment forms. It is where initiative lives. It is where a kid realizes that “clean your room” means looking around, noticing what is wrong, and starting somewhere. Not because the instruction was perfect, but because the situation was obvious.

Common sense is not magic. It is practiced awareness.

That is what drives me crazy when I say, “You didn’t use common sense,” and one of my children looks at me and says, “What do you mean?”

Did I stutter?

I mean you did not think it through. I mean you did not ask the next obvious question in your own head. I mean you saw a problem, stepped over it, and then acted surprised when the problem remained a problem. I mean there was a wet towel on the floor and somehow your brain treated that as a philosophical puzzle instead of an item to hang up.

Am I not speaking in clear English?

Apparently not. Apparently “common sense” now requires a glossary.

And maybe that is part of the issue. We use the phrase like it should be self-explanatory, but common sense is not evenly distributed at birth like eye color or the ability to hate slow Wi-Fi. It has to be modeled, demanded, practiced, and sometimes allowed to fail.

The hard part is letting them fail in small ways while the stakes are still small.

That sounds simple until you are watching your kid fill out a job application and they ask whether they should capitalize their own last name. Then every parental instinct in your body wants to lunge across the table and fix it. Not because they are incapable, but because watching your child struggle with something obvious can feel like watching a raccoon try to open a bank account.

But if we fix every small thing, they never build the muscle.

This is where I have sympathy for kids today, too. Their world is weird. We handed them devices that answer almost any question instantly, then got annoyed when they stopped practicing how to sit with uncertainty. We surrounded them with apps designed to remove friction, then wondered why friction feels unnatural to them. We gave them school systems full of rubrics, portals, reminders, parent emails, missing assignment alerts, and online gradebooks, then acted shocked when they expected life to come with the same dashboard.

We had boredom. They have notifications. We learned things by wandering around, making mistakes, and occasionally being embarrassed in public. They learn under the glowing eye of permanent records, screenshots, and group chats.

So yes, I am frustrated. But I am not blind.

Some of this is on the culture. Some of it is on the technology. Some of it is on schools that reward compliance more than judgment. Some of it is on parents like me who wanted to be helpful and may have accidentally become the human version of an instruction manual.

And some of it is on the kids.

Because at the end of the day, there comes a point when you have to look around your own room and understand that the laundry does not levitate into the hamper through community support. The dishes do not self-identify as clean. The job application does not fill itself out because you feel vaguely interested in having money. Life asks things of you before you feel ready. That is not cruelty. That is adulthood stretching its hamstrings in the doorway.

The problem with needing specific instructions for every task is not just that it annoys parents, though let the record show that it very much does. The problem is that life rarely gives specific instructions.

A boss will not always tell you every sub-task. A spouse will not want to explain, for the nine thousandth time, that “help clean up after dinner” includes the pan on the stove, not just the one fork you personally used. A sick parent, a broken car, a hard conversation, a late bill, a neighbor who needs help, none of these things arrives neatly packaged with a checklist and a cheerful tutorial video.

You have to notice. You have to think. You have to act.

That is the moral center of this whole aggravating little parenting complaint. I do not just want my kids to clean their rooms because I enjoy clear floors, though I do, and I will not apologize for that. I want them to learn how to see what needs doing. I want them to develop the habit of asking, “What is the next right thing here?” without needing someone else to stand over them like a mildly disappointed foreman.

Because common sense, when you strip away the parental sarcasm, is really a form of care.

It means you notice that your mess affects other people. It means you understand that your choices create work for someone else. It means you can look beyond your immediate comfort and see the small obligations sitting right in front of you. Pick up the towel. Fill out the application. Call the manager. Make the bed. Apologize when you were careless. Do the obvious thing before someone has to beg you to do it.

That is not just competence. That is decency.

I want my kids to have initiative not because I need little productivity machines marching through the house with labeled bins and a quarterly plan. I do not want to raise tiny middle managers. Heaven help us, the world has enough of those. I want them to be free. Really free. And freedom takes more than wanting options. It takes the ability to make decisions, solve problems, handle discomfort, and move without being pushed.

The strange thing is that kids often want independence before they want responsibility. I know I did. Every teenager wants the ride, the money, the privacy, the unlocked door, the later curfew, the benefit of being treated as older. Fair enough. I’m with you. Independence sounds fantastic when it is all privileges and no vacuuming.

But responsibility is the price of admission.

You want a job? Go apply. You want money? Learn how to talk to a manager without looking like you are being held hostage. You want a clean room? Start with the floor. You want to be trusted? Practice doing the small thing without being reminded six times and then acting like the reminder was the real crime.

This is where I try, not always successfully, to move from annoyance to teaching. Because yelling “use common sense” may feel satisfying in the moment, but it does not always build the thing I want built. Sometimes I have to ask, “What do you see that needs to be done?” Sometimes I have to resist giving the answer. Sometimes I have to let the application be theirs, not mine.

That part is hard.

It is easier to lecture. It is easier to complain. It is easier to make a joke about needing a federal grant to explain how hampers work. And for sure, I will continue making those jokes, because I am a father and this is one of the few remaining benefits.

But the real work is teaching them to think without doing all the thinking for them.

Maybe that starts with smaller questions. Not “Why are you like this?” which, while emotionally honest, is apparently frowned upon. Maybe it is, “What do you think the next step is?” Maybe it is, “Look around and tell me what you notice.” Maybe it is, “What would you do if I were not here?” Maybe it is refusing to turn every normal task into a guided tour.

Because someday I will not be standing in the doorway.

Someday the room will be theirs. The job will be theirs. The bills, the relationships, the mistakes, the repairs, the hard choices, the messes they made and the messes they inherited will be theirs. I do not say that with doom in my voice. That is just life. We all get handed a room eventually, and nobody else can clean it for us forever.

So yes, when my kids ask, “What do you mean?” after I say something that feels painfully obvious, I may still stare into the middle distance like a man remembering a war. I may still wonder how a human being can locate a meme from 2017 in eight seconds but cannot locate the laundry basket directly in front of him. I may still need a minute.

Oh well.

But underneath the sarcasm, I know what I am really asking for. I am asking them to wake up to the world around them. I am asking them to notice. I am asking them to carry a little more of their own weight, not because I am tired of carrying it, though I am, but because they will need that strength.

I do not need perfect kids.

I just want them to see the towel on the floor.